2025 topics

ST MARY'S DSG, KLOOF

GRADE: 10 **2025**

ENGLISH HOME LANGUAGE
ATONEMENT
LITERATURE ESSAY TOPICS

TIME: 60 MIN + 5 MIN READING TIME

EXAMINER: S MNGUNI **MARKS: 30**
MODERATORS: ENGLISH TEACHERS

Instructions:

1. Answer either **Question 1 or Question 2**. Indicate your choice clearly.

3. Your response must be in the form of a well structured literary essay.

4. Your essay should be approximately 600 words in length.

5. Close and relevant reference to the text in the question is essential.

6. Do NOT provide a word count at the end of your essay.

Take note:
You are encouraged to give your own judgments. Attempt to create space in which your voice can be evident. The examiners will judge your answers on your understanding of, and insight into, the given text and will assess the competence with which your answers are expressed.

QUESTION 1

"McEwan's *Atonement* is a masterful study of how class divisions silently govern the lives of individuals, even as they believe themselves free."
– Emily Gill, Literary Review

"The ruling class not only rules with force, but also with ideas."
— Karl Marx, Das Kapital

The novel *Atonement* illustrates how class shapes the **characters' social positions**,and their ability to **construct the truth** and to **receive justice.**

Discuss the truthfulness of this statement by referring to at least **two characters and two events** in the novel.

OR

QUESTION 2

"Briony Tallis is both the author and the architect of moral chaos."
– James Wood, The New Yorker

Briony is both a **victim of her own imagination and the cause of irreparable damage**. Discuss the truthfulness of this statement.

Your discussion should explore her character and actions, as well as how they impact the plot of the novel.

Topic 2: ChatGPT example essay

QUESTION 2

> **"Briony Tallis is both the author and the architect of moral chaos."**
> *– James Wood, The New Yorker*

Briony is both a **victim of her own imagination** and the **cause of irreparable damage.** Discuss the truthfulness of this statement.

Your discussion should explore her character and actions, as well as how they impact the plot of the novel.

EXAMPLE

In ***Atonement*,** Briony Tallis is presented as both tragically naïve and deeply destructive. James Wood's statement that "Briony Tallis is both the author and the architect of moral chaos" is truthful because **Briony's imagination shapes not only the events of the novel, but also the suffering experienced** by the people around her. However, although Briony causes irreparable damage through **her false accusation of Robbie Turner,** she is also a **victim of her youth, immaturity**, and romantic view of the world. McEwan therefore creates a complex character whose actions are unforgivable, yet understandable.

From the beginning of the novel, Briony is characterised by her active imagination and desire for control. At thirteen years old, she views life as though it were a story that she can organise and direct. This is evident in her obsession with writing plays and arranging performances for her cousins. Briony enjoys creating order because it gives her a sense of certainty and importance. However, this imaginative nature becomes dangerous when she begins interpreting real events through the exaggerated lens of fiction. Instead of understanding the complexities of adult relationships, she simplifies people into heroes and villains. As a result, she wrongly casts Robbie as a threatening figure long before the accusation against him occurs.

Briony's misunderstanding of the fountain scene is the first major example of how her imagination distorts reality. When she witnesses Cecilia removing her clothes and entering the fountain in front of Robbie, she assumes that Robbie is somehow controlling or humiliating Cecilia. Because Briony lacks emotional maturity, she cannot understand the sexual tension between the two characters. Instead, she creates a dramatic narrative in which Cecilia becomes a victim. McEwan deliberately presents this scene from multiple perspectives to show how unreliable Briony's interpretation is. The reader recognises that Briony sees only fragments of the truth, yet she becomes increasingly confident in her false assumptions.

This confusion becomes even more serious after Briony reads Robbie's explicit letter to Cecilia. Although the letter was accidentally delivered, Briony interprets it as proof of Robbie's corruption and moral weakness. Her sheltered upbringing prevents her from understanding adult desire, so she reacts with shock and disgust. Importantly, Briony does not simply misunderstand Robbie; she actively constructs a version of him that fits the dramatic story she has imagined. This supports the idea that she is the "architect of moral chaos," because her choices directly lead to devastating consequences.

The greatest harm Briony causes occurs when she falsely identifies Robbie as Lola's attacker. Despite the darkness and uncertainty surrounding the event, Briony convinces herself that Robbie is guilty. Her testimony results in Robbie's imprisonment and destroys both his future and Cecilia's happiness. Robbie loses the opportunity to study medicine and is separated from Cecilia for years. Cecilia, meanwhile, becomes isolated from her family because she refuses to support Briony's lie. Through these consequences, McEwan emphasises how a single false accusation can permanently alter many lives.

However, Briony is also a victim of her own imagination. At thirteen, she is still a child attempting to understand a confusing adult world. Her desire for order and meaning blinds her to reality. Furthermore, the adults around her fail to guide or challenge her effectively. The Tallis family environment is emotionally distant, and Briony is left alone with her fantasies and assumptions. While this does not excuse her behaviour, it does help explain how such a tragic mistake became possible.

As an adult, Briony recognises the terrible damage she has caused and spends much of her life attempting to atone for it. Her work as a nurse during the war reflects her desire to confront suffering directly rather than escape into fiction. Yet McEwan ultimately suggests that true atonement may be impossible. Robbie and Cecilia die before Briony can fully apologise to them, and her final act of rewriting their ending highlights both the power and the limitations of storytelling. Although Briony can create happiness in fiction, she cannot change reality.

Ultimately, Briony Tallis is both a victim and a perpetrator. Her imagination, immaturity, and misunderstanding lead her to commit an act that destroys innocent lives. At the same time, she herself becomes trapped by guilt and regret for the rest of her life. Through Briony, McEwan explores the dangers of storytelling, the unreliability of perception, and the painful impossibility of fully correcting the past.

PEEL breakdown

Teaching Tip for Grade 10 Learners

A useful way to teach PEEL is:

- **Point** = What is this paragraph about?
- **Evidence** = Where in the novel do we see this?
- **Explanation** = Why does this matter?
- **Link** = How does this connect to the essay question?

You can also show learners that:

- stronger essays often contain **multiple pieces of evidence and explanation** within one paragraph,
- but the paragraph should still revolve around **one clear central point**.

Paragraph 1

P – Point / Topic Sentence

> *From the beginning of the novel, Briony is characterised by her active imagination and desire for control.*

This sentence introduces the main idea of the paragraph.

E – Evidence

> *This is evident in her obsession with writing plays and arranging performances for her cousins.*

This refers directly to events in the novel as proof.

E – Explanation

> *Briony enjoys creating order because it gives her a sense of certainty and importance. However, this imaginative nature becomes dangerous when she begins interpreting real events through the exaggerated lens of fiction.*

These sentences explain the significance of the evidence and analyse Briony's behaviour.

L – Link

> *As a result, she wrongly casts Robbie as a threatening figure long before the accusation against him occurs.*

This links the paragraph back to the essay topic about Briony causing damage and moral chaos.

Paragraph 2

P – Point

> *Briony's misunderstanding of the fountain scene is the first major example of how her imagination distorts reality.*

E – Evidence

> *When she witnesses Cecilia removing her clothes and entering the fountain in front of Robbie, she assumes that Robbie is somehow controlling or humiliating Cecilia.*

E – Explanation

> *Because Briony lacks emotional maturity, she cannot understand the sexual tension between the two characters. Instead, she creates a dramatic narrative in which Cecilia becomes a victim.*

This explains *why* Briony misinterprets the scene.

L – Link

> *The reader recognises that Briony sees only fragments of the truth, yet she becomes increasingly confident in her false assumptions.*

This connects back to the idea that Briony's imagination causes harm.

Paragraph 3

P – Point

> *This confusion becomes even more serious after Briony reads Robbie's explicit letter to Cecilia.*

E – Evidence

> *Although the letter was accidentally delivered, Briony interprets it as proof of Robbie's corruption and moral weakness.*

E – Explanation

> *Her sheltered upbringing prevents her from understanding adult desire, so she reacts with shock and disgust.*

This analyses *why* Briony reacts the way she does.

L – Link

> *This supports the idea that she is the "architect of moral chaos," because her choices directly lead to devastating consequences.*

The paragraph clearly reconnects to the essay question.

Paragraph 4

P – Point

> *The greatest harm Briony causes occurs when she falsely identifies Robbie as Lola's attacker.*

E – Evidence

> *Her testimony results in Robbie's imprisonment and destroys both his future and Cecilia's happiness.*

E – Explanation

> *Robbie loses the opportunity to study medicine and is separated from Cecilia for years.*

The writer explains the impact of Briony's actions.

L – Link

> *Through these consequences, McEwan emphasises how a single false accusation can permanently alter many lives.*

This links the discussion back to the broader thematic focus of the essay.

Paragraph 5

P – Point

> *However, Briony is also a victim of her own imagination.*

E – Evidence

> *At thirteen, she is still a child attempting to understand a confusing adult world.*

E – Explanation

> *Her desire for order and meaning blinds her to reality. Furthermore, the adults around her fail to guide or challenge her effectively.*

This develops insight into Briony's vulnerability.

L – Link

> *While this does not excuse her behaviour, it does help explain how such a tragic mistake became possible.*

This links back to the essay's central argument that Briony is both victim and perpetrator.

Paragraph 6

P – Point

> *As an adult, Briony recognises the terrible damage she has caused and spends much of her life attempting to atone for it.*

E – Evidence

Her work as a nurse during the war reflects her desire to confront suffering directly rather than escape into fiction.

E – Explanation

Yet McEwan ultimately suggests that true atonement may be impossible.

This interprets the significance of Briony's actions.

L – Link

Although Briony can create happiness in fiction, she cannot change reality.

This final link reinforces the central idea of guilt and irreparable damage.

Intro & conclusion tips

Simple Formula for a Literary Essay Introduction

INTRODUCTION FORMULA:

1. Mention the novel and author

2. Address the topic/question

3. State your argument (thesis)

Easy Sentence Structure

> In *[Novel]* by [Author], [brief statement about the topic].
> This is shown through [main ideas/characters/themes].
> Therefore, [your overall argument/judgment].

Example Using *Atonement*

> In *Atonement* by Ian McEwan, Briony Tallis's imagination influences both her understanding of reality and the lives of those around her. This is shown through her false assumptions about Robbie and the devastating consequences of her actions. Therefore, although Briony is a victim of her immaturity and imagination, she is ultimately responsible for causing irreversible damage.

What Makes This Effective?

✔️ Introduces the text

> "In *Atonement* by Ian McEwan…"

✔️ Answers the question directly

> "Briony's imagination influences both her understanding of reality and the lives of those around her."

✔️ Gives a clear argument

> "she is ultimately responsible…"

Simple Formula for a Conclusion

CONCLUSION FORMULA:

1. Restate your argument

2. Summarise the main insight

3. End with a final thought about the novel/theme

Easy Sentence Structure

Ultimately, [main argument].
Through [character/event/theme], the author shows that [main insight].
Therefore, [final meaningful statement].

Example Conclusion

Ultimately, Briony is both a victim of her imagination and the cause of immense suffering. Through her false accusations and later attempts at atonement, McEwan shows how dangerous misinterpretation and unchecked imagination can be. Therefore, the novel suggests that while people may seek forgiveness, some actions can never truly be undone.

A Very Simple “Memory Trick” for Learners

Introduction = TEXT + TOPIC + THESIS

- **TEXT** → name the novel/author
- **TOPIC** → mention the focus of the question
- **THESIS** → give your argument/opinion

Conclusion = THESIS + THEMES + FINAL THOUGHT

- **THESIS** → restate your argument
- **THEMES** → summarise what the novel reveals
- **FINAL THOUGHT** → end meaningfully

Helpful Teaching Tip

Many Grade 10 learners:

- retell the plot in introductions,
- or introduce entirely new ideas in conclusions.

A useful rule is:

Introduction = tell the reader what you will argue.
Conclusion = remind the reader what you proved.

This usually helps learners stay focused and analytical rather than narrative.